17. The Declaration of Independence of the United States, signed 4 July 1776.

Declaration Stone Engraving, courtesy of the National Archives and Records Administration, Washington, DC, "Charters of Freedom."

All these cooperation networks – from the cities of ancient Mesopotamia to the Qin and Roman empires – were 'imagined orders'. The social norms that sustained them were based neither on ingrained instincts nor on personal acquaintances, but rather on belief in shared myths.

How can myths sustain entire empires? We have already discussed one such example: Peugeot. Now let's examine two of the best-known myths of history: the Code of Hammurabi of *c*.1776 BC, which served as a cooperation manual for hundreds of thousands of ancient Babylonians; and the American Declaration of Independence of 1776 AD, which today still serves as a cooperation manual for hundreds of millions of modern Americans.

In 1776 BC Babylon was the world's biggest city. The Babylonian Empire was probably the world's largest, with more than a million subjects. It ruled most of Mesopotamia, including the bulk of modern Iraq and parts of present-day Syria and Iran. The Babylonian king most famous today was Hammurabi. His fame is due primarily to the text that bears his name, the Code of Hammurabi. This was a collection of laws and judicial decisions whose aim was to present Hammurabi as a role model of a just king, serve as a basis for a more uniform legal system across the Babylonian Empire, and teach future generations what justice is and how a just king acts.

Future generations took notice. The intellectual and bureaucratic elite of ancient Mesopotamia canonised the text, and apprentice scribes continued to copy it long after Hammurabi died and his empire lay in ruins. Hammurabi's Code is therefore a good source for understanding the ancient Mesopotamians' ideal of social order.[3]

The text begins by saying that the gods Anu, Enlil and Marduk – the leading deities of the Mesopotamian pantheon – appointed Hammurabi 'to make justice prevail in the land, to abolish the wicked and the evil, to prevent the strong from oppressing the weak'.[4] It then lists about 300 judgements, given in the set formula 'If such and such a thing happens, such is the judgment.' For example, judgements 196–9 and 209–14 read:

196. If a superior man should blind the eye of another superior man, they shall blind his eye.
197. If he should break the bone of another superior man, they shall break his bone.